

Primary Source Reading 1: Truman's Statement Announcing the Bomb

Philosophy Honors: Ethics / Lesson 2.01 — A Decision That Divided the World Statement by the President, August 6, 1945 (Source: National Archives)

Before you read: This is the official White House statement released hours after the bomb was dropped on Hiroshima. As you read, look specifically for the reasons Truman gives — not just the facts he reports — and ask whether his justification is aimed at outcomes, at rights and duties, or at something else entirely. This is exactly the question your notebook assignment asks you to answer.

The Announcement

Sixteen hours ago an American airplane dropped one bomb on Hiroshima, an important Japanese Army base. That bomb had more power than 20,000 tons of T.N.T. It had more than two thousand times the blast power of the British “Grand Slam” which is the largest bomb ever yet used in the history of warfare.

The Japanese began the war from the air at Pearl Harbor. They have been repaid many fold. And the end is not yet. With this bomb we have now added a new and revolutionary increase in destruction to supplement the growing power of our armed forces. In their present form these bombs are now in production and even more powerful forms are in development.

It is an atomic bomb. It is a harnessing of the basic power of the universe. The force from which the sun draws its power has been loosed against those who brought war to the Far East.

The Race Against Germany

Before 1939, it was the accepted belief of scientists that it was theoretically possible to release atomic energy. But no one knew any practical method of doing it. By 1942, however, we knew that the Germans were working feverishly to find a way to add atomic energy to the other engines of war with which they hoped to enslave the world. But they failed. We may be grateful to Providence that the Germans got the V-1's and V-2's late and in limited quantities and even more grateful that they did not get the atomic bomb at all.

The battle of the laboratories held fateful risks for us as well as the battles of the air, land and sea, and we have now won the battle of the laboratories as we have won the other battles.

Beginning in 1940, before Pearl Harbor, scientific knowledge useful in war was pooled between the United States and Great Britain, and many priceless helps to our victories have come from that arrangement. Under that general policy the research on the

atomic bomb was begun. With American and British scientists working together we entered the race of discovery against the Germans.

The Scale of the Undertaking

We have spent two billion dollars on the greatest scientific gamble in history—and won.

But the greatest marvel is not the size of the enterprise, its secrecy, nor its cost, but the achievement of scientific brains in putting together infinitely complex pieces of knowledge held by many men in different fields of science into a workable plan... What has been done is the greatest achievement of organized science in history. It was done under high pressure and without failure.

The Warning to Japan

We are now prepared to obliterate more rapidly and completely every productive enterprise the Japanese have above ground in any city. We shall destroy their docks, their factories, and their communications. Let there be no mistake; we shall completely destroy Japan's power to make war.

It was to spare the Japanese people from utter destruction that the ultimatum of July 26 was issued at Potsdam. Their leaders promptly rejected that ultimatum. If they do not now accept our terms they may expect a rain of ruin from the air, the like of which has never been seen on this earth. Behind this air attack will follow sea and land forces in such numbers and power as they have not yet seen and with the fighting skill of which they are already well aware.

What Comes Next

I shall recommend that the Congress of the United States consider promptly the establishment of an appropriate commission to control the production and use of atomic power within the United States. I shall give further consideration and make further recommendations to the Congress as to how atomic power can become a powerful and forceful influence towards the maintenance of world peace.

After you read: Notice what kind of reasons Truman actually offers. He points to Pearl Harbor and repayment ("they have been repaid many fold"), to the choice between this weapon and the alternative of continued conventional destruction ("a rain of ruin from the air"), and to the outcome he is seeking — Japan's surrender and the end of the war. He does not argue that the people of Hiroshima had forfeited a right, or that some duty required this action regardless of consequences. For your notebook, look closely at whether Truman's justification here is best described as consequentialist, deontological, or some mixture — and note that a public statement written to justify a decision to the American people may emphasize different reasons than the private deliberations that actually produced it.